

THE GUPTA EMPIRE + HARSHA

Golden Age • Nine Gems • The Vardhana Dynasty

From the Gupta Golden Age (320–543 AD) to the rise and fall of Harshavardhana's post-Gupta Vardhana dynasty.

- Headings & Definitions ● Explanations ● Highlighter = Key Facts 🎯 Exam Tip ✗ Common Mistake
🧠 Memory Trick

StudyPlanner



View:



Page-by-Page



Continuous Scroll



Print

THE GUPTA EMPIRE — ORIGINS, CHANDRAGUPTA I + SAMUDRAGUPTA

The Gupta Empire lasted from 320 AD to 543 AD — a period so prosperous in art, science and literature that it is called the Golden Age of ancient India. The Gupta Empire was not as extensive as the earlier Maurya Empire, but it still covered a vast area.

The Founder — Shri Gupta

The dynasty was founded by **Shri Gupta**. He is believed to have been the son of a Kushan ruler ("Kushansha") — though this detail is rarely tested in exams.



Low-Priority Detail

Shri Gupta is believed to be the son of a Kushan ruler (Kushansha) — interesting background, but rarely the subject of exam questions!



Fig 1: From Shri Gupta to Samudragupta

Shri Gupta
Founder of the dynasty



Chandragupta I (320-335)
Title: Maharajadhiraja
Wife: Kumar Devi (Licchavi)
Gold coins: Dinars



Samudragupta (335-375)
Prayag Prashasti (by Harisena)
Won 24 battles
"Napoleon of India" (V.A. Smith)
Depicted playing veena on coins

Shri Gupta (founder)

→ Chandragupta I '320-335

→ Samudragupta '335-375

★ Chandragupta I (320-335 AD)

- Assumed the title **Maharajadhiraja**
- Married **Kumar Devi**, a Licchavi princess
- Introduced gold coins known as **Dinars**

Samudragupta (335-375 AD)

Samudragupta succeeded Chandragupta I. An inscription associated with him is the **Prayag Prashasti** ("Prashasti" = praise/eulogy), composed by his court poet **Harisena**.

- From the Prayag Prashasti, we learn he won **24 battles**
- Historian **V. A. Smith** (Vincent Arthur Smith) gave him the title "**Napoleon of India**"
- He also held the titles **Kaviraja** and **Sarva-rajochchheta** ("Procurator of All Kings")
- He is depicted **playing the veena** on his coins

📖 Samudragupta's Other Titles (tap to expand) ▼

Ruler Comparison

Ruler	Period	Title(s)	Key Fact
-------	--------	----------	----------

Chandragupta I	320–335 AD	Maharajadhiraja	Wife: Kumar Devi; introduced Dinars
Samudragupta	335–375 AD	Kaviraja, Sarva-rajochchheta	Prayag Prashasti; 24 battles; "Napoleon of India"

Exam Tip

Chandragupta I → Samudragupta → (later) Chandragupta II — don't confuse the numbering; these are three different kings across roughly 95 years!

Common Mistake

Don't confuse Chandragupta I's **Dinars** (his gold coins) with his **title** (Maharajadhiraja) — two completely different things!

Memory Trick

"Prayag Prashasti" = praise at Prayag — composed by Harisena in **praise** (Prashasti) of Samudragupta's 24 victories, hence the "Napoleon of India" title!

Page 1 of 5

← Previous

Next →

CHANDRAGUPTA II — VIKRAMADITYA + THE NINE GEMS

Chandragupta II was the son of Samudragupta. He first sidelined his brother Ramagupta, then married his brother's wife, Dhruvadevi.

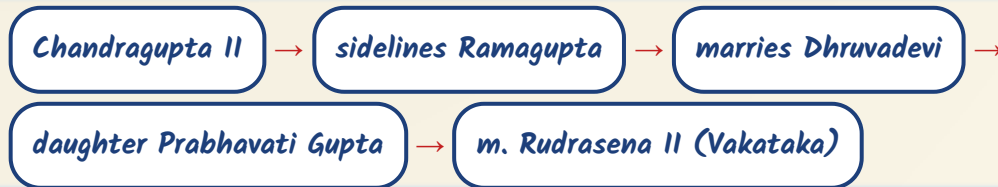


Context Matters

Hearing just "he sidelined his brother and married his wife" makes Chandragupta II sound harsh — but there were fuller reasons behind these events than a short summary can capture!

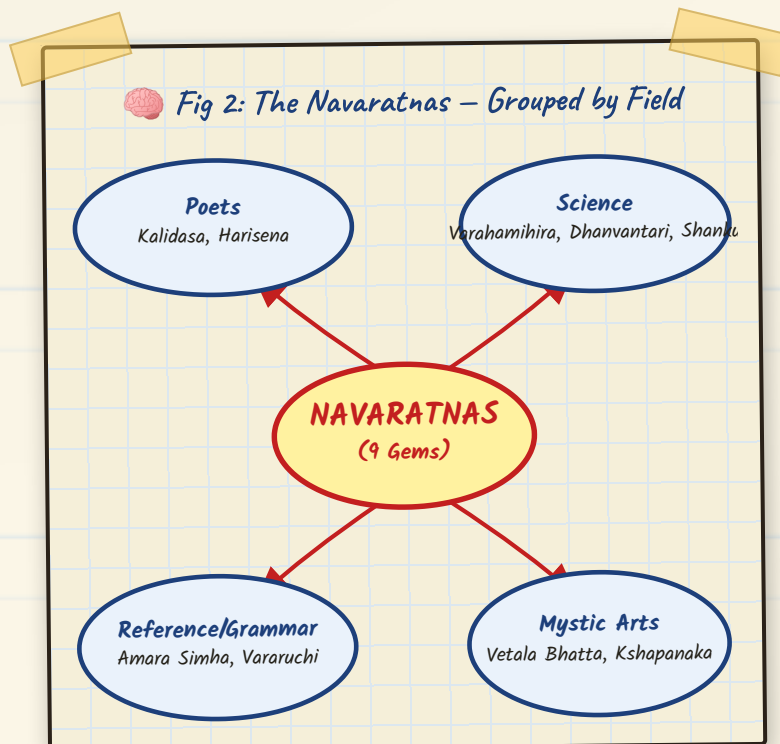
Marriage Alliance with the Vakatakas

Chandragupta II got his daughter, **Prabhavati Gupta**, married to the Vakataka ruler **Rudrasena II**. After Rudrasena II's death, Chandragupta II began to indirectly control the Vakataka Empire as well.



Chandragupta II took the title **Vikramaditya**.

Nine Gems (Navaratnas) of His Court



Gem	Role
Kalidasa	Poet & dramatist
Harisena	Court poet
Amara Simha	Lexicographer & librarian
Vararuchi	Grammarian
Varahamihira	Astronomer
Dhanvantari	Physician
Shanku	Architect

Vetala Bhatta

Magician

Kshapanaka

Astrologer

 Kalidasa's Major Works (tap to expand) ▼

Also during Chandragupta II's reign, the first **Chinese traveller** came to India — **Fa-Hien** (Faxian).

Exam Tip

9 Gems by field: **Poets** (Kalidasa, Harisena), **Reference/Grammar** (Amara Simha, Vararuchi), **Science** (Varahamihira, Dhanvantari, Shanku), **Mystic Arts** (Vetala Bhatta, Kshapanaka).

Common Mistake

Don't confuse Chandragupta II's title **Vikramaditya** with Chandragupta I's title **Maharajadhiraja** — different titles, different kings, one generation apart!

Memory Trick

Marriage chain: Chandragupta II's daughter Prabhavati Gupta → married Rudrasena II (Vakataka) → after his death, Chandragupta II indirectly controlled Vakataka territory too!

Page 2 of 5

← Previous

Next →



KUMARAGUPTA, SKANDAGUPTA + GUPTA ADMINISTRATION

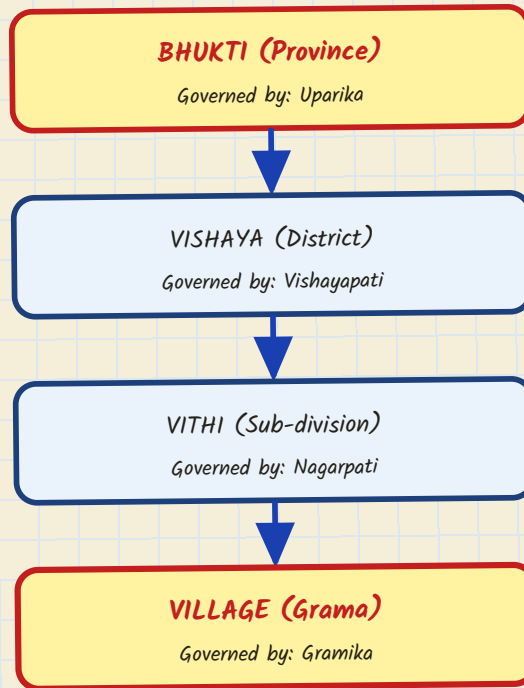
Kumaragupta & Skandagupta

- Kumaragupta built **Nalanda University**
- The **Huns** first attacked India during Kumaragupta's time
- **Skandagupta** successfully resisted and repelled the Huns' attacks

- Skandagupta also had the **Sudarshan Lake** repaired — recorded in the **Junagadh Rock Inscription** (the same inscription that tells us about Rudradaman, the Shaka ruler)

 *The Sudarshan Lake Story (tap to expand) ▼*

 *Fig 3: Gupta Administrative Hierarchy*



Key Officials

Post	Role
Kumaramatyā	Most important official
Mahadandanayaka	Officer of justice (punishment)
Sandhivigrahika	Officer of war and peace
Nagara Shreshthi	Chief banker

 *Exam trivia: "Which post did Harisena NOT hold — Kumaramatyā, Mahadandanayaka, Sandhivigrahika, or Nagara Shreshthi?"*

Answer: Harisena did **not** hold the post of **Nagara Shreshthi** (chief banker) — he was the court poet instead.

Administration – Decentralised Structure

Gupta administration was quite decentralised. The empire was divided into **Bhukti** (province, governed by the **Uparika**) → **Vishaya** (district, governed by the **Vishayapati**) → **Vithi** (sub-division, governed by the **Nagarpati**) → **Village** (governed by the **Gramika**).

Taxes

Tax	Meaning
Bhaga	1/6th of produce (levied since Mauryan/Ashoka era, not new)
Bhoga	Offerings to the king (fruits, flowers, etc.)
Bali	Originally voluntary; later became compulsory
Plough tax	Fee for owning a plough
Udakabhaga	Tax on water
Vishti	Labour obligation — could be paid off with money



Not Quite "Forced"

Vishti wasn't literally unpaid forced labour for everyone — if you had money, you could pay your way out of the labour obligation instead!



Exam Tip

Kumaragupta built Nalanda; Skandagupta fought the Huns — remember: "K for Knowledge (Nalanda), S for Security (Huns)"!



Common Mistake

Don't mix up who did what to the Sudarshan Lake! **Pushyagupta Vaishya** built it; **Rudradaman** repaired it first; **Skandagupta** repaired it again later — three different people, one lake!



Memory Trick

Administrative ladder, top to bottom: **Bhukti** (Uparika) → **Vishaya** (Vishayapati) → **Vithi** (Nagarpati) → **Village** (Gramika)!

Page 3 of 5

← Previous

Next →



GUPTA ART, ARCHITECTURE + THE VAKATAKA DYNASTY

Temples & Sculpture

- **Bhitargaon Temple** (Kanpur, Uttar Pradesh) — India's oldest brick temple, dedicated to Lord Krishna
- **Dashavatara Temple** — Lalitpur, Uttar Pradesh
- **Varaha idol** — at Udayagiri, Vidisha, Madhya Pradesh; Varaha is the boar incarnation of Lord Vishnu, taken to rescue/protect the earth
- **Bagh Caves** — also in Madhya Pradesh, associated with Gupta-era cave art



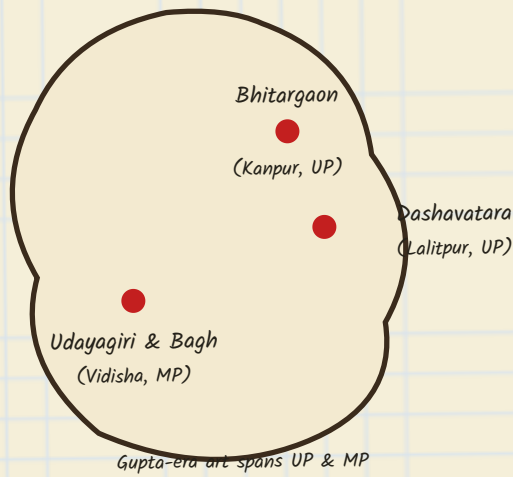
Fun Fact

The Varaha (boar) avatar of Vishnu is shown physically rescuing the Earth — that's the symbolism behind the Udayagiri idol!



Fig 4: Gupta-Era Monuments — Where They Stand





Monument	Location	Significance
Bhitargaon Temple	Kanpur, UP	India's oldest brick temple; Krishna
Dashavatara Temple	Lalitpur, UP	Depicts the 10 avatars of Vishnu
Varaha idol	Udayagiri, Vidisha, MP	Boar incarnation rescuing the earth
Bagh Caves	Madhya Pradesh	Gupta-era cave art

Bhitargaon (UP)



Dashavatara (UP)



Udayagiri (MP)



Bagh Caves (MP)

❌ Common Mistake

Udayagiri (Madhya Pradesh, Vidisha — the Varaha idol, Gupta era) is *not* the same as Udayagiri-Khandagiri caves (Odisha — built by King Kharavela)! Same name, different states, different eras!

The Vakataka Dynasty

The Vakatakas were contemporaries of the Guptas. Their founder was **Vindhyashakti**; their capital was Pravarapura (not very significant in itself). The Vakatakas were feudatories of the Satavahanas.



The Vakataka Dynasty (tap to expand) ▼



Exam Tip

Bhitargaon (UP) = oldest BRICK temple; Dashavatara Temple (UP), Varaha idol at Udayagiri (MP) & Bagh Caves (MP) — remember them state-wise!



Memory Trick

Two temples, one state (UP): Bhitargaon (Kanpur) for Krishna, Dashavatara Temple (Lalitpur) for Vishnu's 10 avatars!

Page 4 of 5

← Previous

Next →



POST-GUPTA ERA — HARSHAVARDHANA + THE VARDHANA DYNASTY

After the Guptas, several regional dynasties emerged: the Pushyabhuti/Vardhana dynasty, the Maukharis, the Gauda kingdom in Bengal, and the Maitrakas. Most exam questions come from the Vardhana (Pushyabhuti) Dynasty.



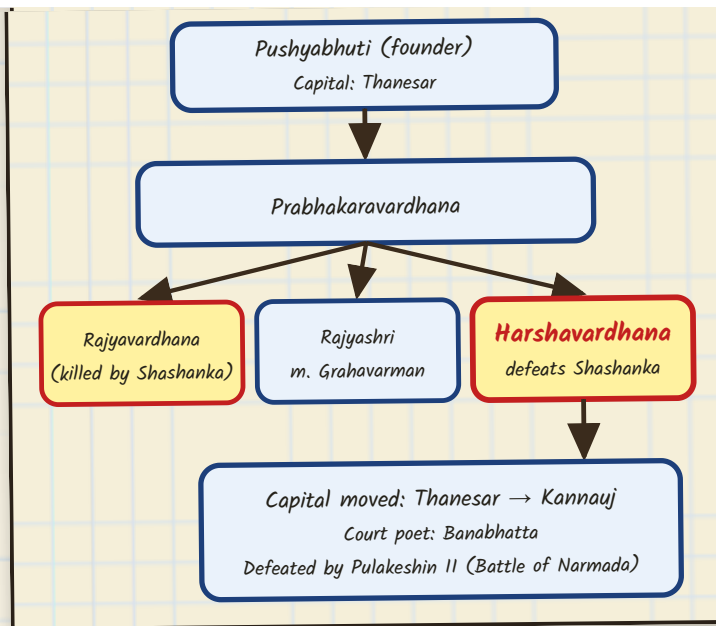
The Vardhana Dynasty

- Founder: Pushyabhuti; capital: Thanesar (present-day Haryana)
- Pushyabhuti's son: Prabhakaravardhana
- Prabhakaravardhana had two sons — Rajyavardhana and Harshavardhana — and a daughter, Rajyashri
- Rajyashri married Grahavarman, king of the Maukhari dynasty



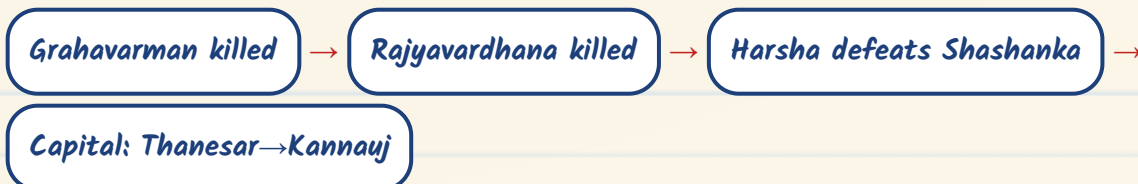
Fig 5: The Vardhana Family & the Rise of Harsha





The Chain of Revenge

Shashanka, king of Gauda, killed Grahavarman. Rajyavardhana set out to avenge this — but Shashanka killed Rajyavardhana too. **Harshavardhana** then defeated Shashanka and began his reign.



The Maukhari Dynasty (tap to expand) ▼



Fun Fact

Kannauj was earlier known as **Kanyakubja** — Harsha shifted his capital here from Thanesar once the Maukhari line ended!

Harsha's Court & Literary World

Harsha's court poet was **Banabhatta**, who composed **Harshacharita** (Harsha's biography) and **Kadambari**. Harsha himself authored three plays: **Ratnavali**, **Priyadarshika**, and **Nagananda**.

Work	Author	Type
Harshacharita	Banabhatta	Biography of Harsha

Kadambari	Banabhatta	Prose romance
Ratnavali	Harsha (himself)	Play
Priyadarshika	Harsha (himself)	Play
Nagananda	Harsha (himself)	Play

A Chinese traveller, **Hsuan Tsang** (also known as **Xuanzang**), visited India during Harsha's reign and wrote a detailed account of his travels.

Harsha vs. Pulakeshin II – the Battle of Narmada

Harsha crossed the **Narmada River** hoping to expand southward, but was defeated by **Pulakeshin II** of the Chalukya dynasty — a clash known as the **Battle of Narmada**. This defeat stopped all of Harsha's southward expeditions.

Harsha had no son, so his dynasty did not continue after him. His daughter was married into the **Maitraka dynasty** (capital: Vallabhi, Gujarat).



Exam Tip

Harsha's own 3 plays — Ratnavali, Priyadarshika, Nagananda — are separate from Banabhatta's Harshacharita (his biography) and Kadambari!



Common Mistake

Don't confuse **Harshacharita** (written BY Banabhatta ABOUT Harsha) with Harsha's OWN plays (Ratnavali, Priyadarshika, Nagananda) — different authors entirely!



Memory Trick

Revenge chain: Shashanka kills Grahavarman → kills Rajyavardhana → Harshavardhana defeats Shashanka and takes the throne!



Exam-Ready Summary

- **Gupta Golden Age:** 320–543 AD
- **Chandragupta I:** Maharajadhiraja, wife Kumar Devi, Dinars
- **Samudragupta:** Prayag Prashasti, 24 battles, "Napoleon of India"
- **Chandragupta II:** title Vikramaditya, Navaratnas, Fa-Hien's visit

- **Kumaragupta:** built Nalanda; **Skandagupta:** repelled the Huns, repaired Sudarshan Lake
- **Harshavardhana:** defeated Shashanka, capital at Kannauj, defeated by Pulakeshin II at the Battle of Narmada

Page 5 of 5

← Previous

 Print Notes

Ancient Indian History · The Gupta Empire & Harsha · SSC / UPSC / Railways / Banking Exam Notes

StudyPlanner